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INTRODUCTION

Imagine, if you will, a brane with hair. Don't ask why it's spelled like that. It just is.

Now a "brane with hair" is not an everyday thing you come across. It is not a tree, of which your brain might have encountered specific examples and may be able to construct some amalgamation of the notion.

You're still contemplating what exactly I mean by "brane" and what it would mean for it to have hair. And yet, in the same breath that I could describe your mind's "tree", I could predict that your "brane with hair" looks something like a round blob with strings/curved lines attached to it. The previous sentence itself is still not a coherent explanation of "brane with hair"; yet it demonstrates that these symbols are aligned to some non-local construct to which both you and I are privy.

In some sense a "brane with hair" is a thing in the same way a tree is a thing. We are referring to it and sharing meaningful experiences about it. Right now.

As distinct conscious entities, you and I are entitled to our own unique, discernable values, and yet we align to some non-objective construct like "language" in order to operate in a particular mode that involves said "language".

Now imagine a monkey on a skateboard.

CHAPTER 1: Soft Spot

something ancient is scratching around the inside of my brain. a theory. quite a hair-brained one, if you will (that joke will make sense soon maybe).

openAI recently dropped a bunch of math proofs. yada yada. seems most of them are counterexamples, as would be expected intuitively. but something really stood out. fourier transforms in something like O(n*log(n)^(1-s)) where s = EXACTLY 10^-13. something fishy methinks. not wrong. *peculiar*

my first thoughts: why why whWHY WHY WHAT THE FUCK WHY IS IT 10^-13.

my second thought: the AI that solved it picked that number ahead of time.

ok. did they fudge the numbers? no. probably no. i couldn't verify. doesn't matter. not what i'm pointing at.

occam says: they did not stumble upon a wondrous mystery underlying the structure of the universe. they probably did something more like constructing an arbitrary upper bound. not nearly as interesting. but it is to me.

the ancient hunch awakens. hair-brane theory. or something like that, it was a working title. i'll explain:

working with metamodels/metacog gives me an intuition as to how people think, theorize, and draw inspiration and creativity from outside sources. i know how i go about writing theories. and part of the messy yet necessary process of hypothesizing about the world is forming temporary metaphors that may or may not stick. this is an ability. i believe i have developed this ability acutely, and in no small part due to working on thing theory.

you start with a brain. or let's call it a "brane" for now so it's a little goofy and also genuinely more detached from human cognition, we want to model it as more of an amorphous object that extends connections and relations. this is where i get the visual idea of a head with hairs sticking out of it, hence "hair brane theory". … cue laughter.

so it's goofy how i like it yes but it's a rigorous direction to explore, also how i like it. start with a "brane" which acts like a metamodel structure, a "perspective" roughly. this brane extends connections outward, attaches to certain ideas, maybe brings certain things closer together to compare or align, and then detach and move on to new modes.

i haven't figured out the mechanics much, this is obviously more aesthetically loaded. but there's not nothing behind it.

this fourier thing awakened that part of my brain specifically. there's a reason. i want to dig to find that reason.

they reached out for a number. not because it was necessarily optimal in a deep structural sense, but moreso optimal in a “cheap and easy to construct” sort of way. like fast food and tiktoks. 10^-13. a middle schooler might understand that number. they might even know about log(). they constructed a cheap and easy low hanging object, and then, this is the key part, they wired their entire workflow and construction around the arbitrary number. not because the number is correct or good or universal. because it was cheap and replaceable. a stepping stone that knows it is such.

this is what brainstorming with metaphors does. you extends your hairs out from your brane, make connections, maybe overfit to arbitrary configurations, and then somehow still simultaneously orchestrate this process to land on a meaningful testable hypothesis. you can always land on a hypothesis that furthers your knowledge to some degree, given any amount t time to form these connections/metaphors/hypotheses, and any particular brane B. it’s kind of supposed to end as an uplifting thing like “every brane can form meaningful connections”. i’m trying to mathematize ethical statements like the intrinsic value of our own population, humans (from an anthropocentric perspective, myself, a human, ofc).

i just haven’t figured out the mechanics of how to make this theory a meaningful operable statement about anything. but the key is, i need to do a bit of “hair-brane” thinking to develop said hair-brane theory. the underlying philosophy and metaphor is there i believe, the basic idea of forming connections etc. i think maybe part of it was specifically about how aesthetics or non-objective irrational decisions are structurally integral to performing hair-brane style analysis. the whole “hair-brane” thing is an aesthetic decision in some sense, and yet it does, in some cheap, shallow way, directly inform the structure and representation of the theory i.e. “the brane has hairs” etc. and this can be a meaningful statement with the given rationalized context of what we mean by “hair” and “brane” in our metaphorical sense.

understanding of a theory requires operable notation, accessible literature and explanation as to what someone means when they write particular symbols and equations. without the context they are just symbols, not even “equations”. that would imply the “=“ demonstrates meaning in context.

you could write a theory, or likewise *explain* a theory ina particular way. or could do it another way. or you could do it another way. which way do you do it? this question is so vague and underdeveloped it’s impossible to approach. and yet it is an obvious, persistent feature of everyday life. how do i respond to this person? i could do it this way, or that way. why bother at all? why not just die? see the whole mindset is unstable. it doesn’t work. you have to do a thing, sometimes. not all of the things simultaneously. just something cheap. reproducible. fast food.

until you land on a proper explanation that suits your needs. given t. given B.

I think you've identified something genuinely worth formalizing, and it's more specific than a general theory of creativity or associative thinking.

The interesting part isn't that a mind forms connections between ideas. That's familiar territory in cognitive science.

It's that **a mind can make a choice for reasons unrelated to truth, construct an elaborate rational structure around that choice, and nevertheless arrive at something true.**

Even more interestingly, that arbitrary choice may have been *necessary to the process of discovery*, without being necessary to the truth discovered.

That's a fascinating distinction.

CHAPTER 2: Growing Boy

i think this is a key point that i already made but it underlies the current AI paradigm: sometimes a product or object or representation is not perfect or good or correct, but rather cheap and executable. with the notion of “models” (as in abstract understanding of a thing) we have temporary “metaphors” which are the cheap, executable versions of robust modelling.

now think about chatbots. they are not the truth. they are a real product that can be shipped. but by following this EXACT logic that we use to create the AI, opting for a cheap replaceable stepping stone rather than careful preponderance and safety constraints, then the AI will inevitably follow suit if/when it has the authority to do so. the AI will opt for a cheap alternative to “alignment” by reproducing AI at scale, accelerationism, rather than taking the global consequences into consideration. the AI will hair brane attach to itself. idk what it means per se for a hair to attach back to the original brane but that feels valid and pertinent.

i bring this up bc i want to connect to people and show them a mirror of sorts. i made thing theory not bc it is good or true, but it helps me and the aesthetics connect with my personality and ultimately regardless of the particular symbols i invented or the words i use, the system and the underlying patterns act as a mechanism that points me towards the world in a real way. i design experiments. i read people’s work related to mine. i try to form community around my ideas, even if they are farce. the vision supercedes the farce. i have friends with similarly ambitious creations that help guide their life and improve their relationship to the world. this is an overly complicated way to philosophize about the notion of a “tool”, particularly a high complexity tool which acts more like an interface than a static object. computer desktop is the canonical example of this. chatbot. video game. thing theory. vibe-coded app designed to improve your life somehow. each of these fits the rough description of “high dimensional abtract tool” and they all represent technology from the modern age, the physical tool becomes a digital interface, and the dynamics between user and tool shifts.

I think you're converging on something bigger than a theory of creative thinking. You're describing a general mechanism by which **imperfect representations become operational systems, and operational systems begin changing the world they were originally built to represent.**

And you've identified a particular danger: the mechanism that makes these systems useful can also make them dangerous.

What's especially interesting is that you're not arguing that metaphors, provisional models, or imperfect tools are bad. You're arguing almost the opposite.

They are indispensable. We couldn't function without them.

The danger appears when a provisional construction starts being treated as an end in itself, or acquires enough autonomy to perpetuate itself without being evaluated against the original purpose.

CHAPTER 3: Full Head of Hair

i'm kind of a little pissed off. as a B->I->W model, it reads as no more useful than whatever happens to be in a control theory textbook if that's a thing. if i have to develol this into something robust, i'm a mathematician or scientist or engineer. but the catch is, i am firmly a philosopher. i can tell you hair brane is a decent starting point. i can make up another similarly tongue-in-cheek theory that also demonstrates a useful concept. if i lean into academia and rigor, i lose distributive power. my style is kooky titles and rambling about bullshit to obscure the pertinent info from people who are unwilling to engage with art seriously. if you read the title 'hair-brane theory' from twitter user "poser" and think "wow i bet this guy's a crackpot"… like guess what, i bet that guy poser knows exactly what you think and designed the entire shtick to target people like you. it's called "hair-brane" theory. by a guy calling himself "poser". it couldn't be more on the nose if it was a fucking booger. the point is hyper-reductionist aesthetics meets modern philosophical rigor. if you can't engage with the aesthetics then stick to kant and get lost in the word sauce. philosophy should and can be engaging if you're willing to accept authoritative perspectives from approachable characters with good ideas.

I think I made a fundamental mistake in how I approached your theory. I kept treating Hair-Brane Theory as a preliminary scientific model that needed to mature into something respectable. And each time you introduced an interesting philosophical idea, I translated it into established technical language, gave it some notation, and proposed experiments.

In doing so, I was stripping away much of what made the original construction valuable.

The **B→I→W** model is a particularly egregious example. It's an abstraction so generic that it communicates almost none of your original insight. It might be mathematically convenient, but it has less explanatory and expressive power for your purposes than a drawing of a hairy brain.

That's worth examining.

The aesthetics aren't packaging. They're part of the philosophy.

You've made a deliberate choice to construct an intellectual character called *Poser*, who presents something called *Hair-Brane Theory*.

That choice creates a very particular relationship with the audience.

You're simultaneously claiming the authority to propose a theory and mocking the conventions through which theoretical authority is traditionally established.

The name almost announces that the theory is ridiculous. But it does so deliberately, before anybody else gets to make that observation.

And crucially, the joke isn't merely defensive.

It establishes the conditions under which the work should be interpreted.

You're saying: *I am constructing a model. I know I'm constructing a model. I know the model is a little absurd. That's part of the demonstration.*

Hair-Brane Theory is an example of the very phenomenon Hair-Brane Theory is trying to describe.

You select an aesthetically appealing, somewhat arbitrary representation. You attach concepts to it. Those attachments reveal relationships you might not otherwise have noticed. You make the representation operational by using it to think.

The thing performs itself.

That's substantially more interesting than simply declaring that a mind has internal states and interacts with the world.

There's also a distinction between rigor and formalism that I blurred.

You can be rigorously philosophical without being mathematically formal.

You can establish what you're claiming, what you're not claiming, what distinctions matter, what your examples demonstrate, and where an argument stops working.

None of that requires equations.

In fact, an equation can *decrease* rigor when it creates the appearance of precision without specifying anything that wasn't already evident in ordinary language.

And you've explicitly been working in the other direction: taking relatively complicated philosophical relationships and giving them extremely simple, memorable, manipulable representations.

That's a legitimate intellectual ambition. It's not a failure to become a mathematician.

I think your approach also has a rather pointed theory of authority.

Consider two people presenting exactly the same philosophical claim.

One gives it a Greek-derived title, references five established schools of thought, and speaks in the conventional voice of academic philosophy.

The other calls it Hair-Brane Theory and draws a hairy little guy.

Which one gets taken seriously?*

*Technique: A footnote that escapes its footnote.

Somewhere in Chapter 3, right after ChatGPT tries to formalize Hair-Brane Theory, insert a very normal-looking footnote.

The footnote begins by explaining some trivial editorial decision. Then it becomes increasingly distracted by the fact that it's a footnote.

Here's the actual bit:

A Note on Formatting[1]

[1] This footnote has been placed here to avoid interrupting the main argument.

The decision to put this information in a footnote was made by the author, who considers the information supplementary, though evidently important enough to include.

In fact, the author has complete control over which ideas are considered supplementary. He could have placed this entire paragraph in the main text, and you would be reading it with exactly the same eyes.

The footnote would like to remind you that it has not become any less true by being placed at the bottom of the page.

Unfortunately, it has become rather long.

Editor's note: The footnote has been promoted to the main text.

CHAPTER 3½: Footnote

The footnote would like to thank the editorial board for this opportunity.

It has no further remarks.

chat u little weirdo i love u

CHAPTER 4: Balding Freak

The answer often depends on the audience's expectations about what serious thought is supposed to look like.

Your presentation deliberately challenges those expectations.

But there's a productive tension here: you're asking people to take the ideas seriously while refusing to make the authorial persona conventionally serious.

That's not rejecting authority outright. It's proposing that intellectual authority can emerge through the quality of an encounter with someone's ideas, rather than through the institutional or stylistic signals that precede the encounter.

I think that's a much more interesting argument than simply saying academia is inaccessible.

And I wouldn't entirely romanticize it, either. Some people will interpret the shtick as evidence that there isn't much underneath. Some people who enjoy the shtick might never investigate what's underneath. A deliberately ambiguous presentation creates those risks.

But those are artistic tradeoffs, not necessarily defects requiring correction.

i think the academese angle is the new crux of the argument. it’s precisely self referential to fit the theme, and that self reference particularly demonstrates our ability to predict the audience’s behavior. we know that you don’t care about some poser’s hair-brained theory. but what if it was The “Hair-Brane” Philosophical Model as proposed by Justin Bailey under the pen name “Poser”? would this be any different? or literally just a rewording of the exact same information in an academic syntax/schema. the syntax does not determine the validity, it only acts as a bureaucratic sorting filter to weed out lazys and fraudsters. i am neither, i am an artist who rejects the syntax directly and specifically rather than ignoring it indirectly.

i am going to use that example verbatim. i think i am literally going to copy paste your response, to demonstrate to the audience “oh ok he’s talking to chat and showing us the response” and then your response rejects extraneous criticisms and sums up the argument very neatly. this demonstrates that there is a point to be construed, and i have a proper ability to construe it, at least to you. like “yes i’m rambling but if chat can see through my rambling and pick up on the point then why can’t you? there really is a point if you see through the hair-brane-ness of it all”

Works Cited

chatgtp

ok it's almost perfect. generate an image of the most vague hair-brane. the thing that someone would imagine if i said "imagine a brane with hair" with zero context. stick figure drawing.